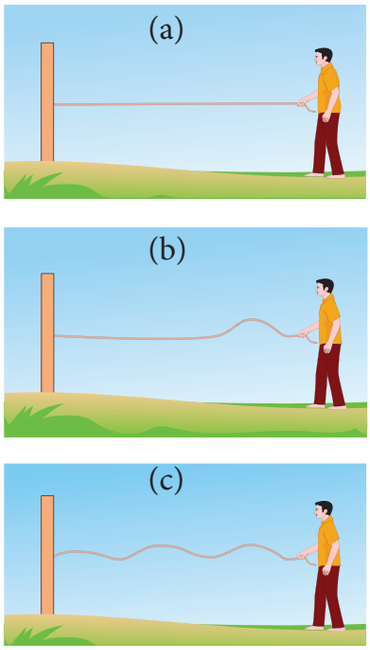


Figure 11.4: Wave pulse created during jerk produced on one end of the string

11.1.3 Formation of waves in a tuning fork

When we strike a tuning fork on a rubber pad, the prongs of the tuning fork vibrate about their mean positions. The prong vibrating about a mean position means moving outward and inward, as indicated in the Figure 11.5. When a prong moves outward, it pushes the layer of air in its neighbourhood which means there is more accumulation of air molecules in this region. Hence, the density and also the pressure increase. These regions are known as compressed regions or compressions. This compressed air layer moves forward and compresses the next neighbouring layer in a similar manner. Thus a wave of compression advances or passes through air. When the prong moves inwards, the particles of the medium are moved to the right. In this region both density and pressure are low. It is known as a rarefaction or elongation.

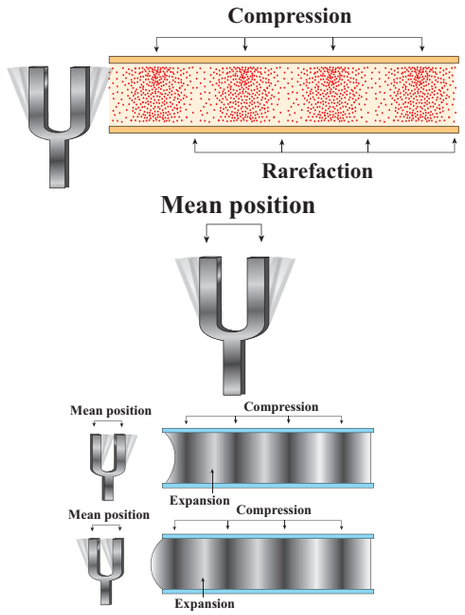


Figure 11.5 Waves due to strike of a tuning fork on a rubber pad

11.1.4 Characteristics of wave motion

- For the propagation of the waves, the medium must possess both inertia and elasticity, which decide the velocity of the wave in that medium.
- In a given medium, the velocity of a wave is a constant whereas the constituent particles in that medium move with different velocities at different positions. Velocity is maximum at their mean position and zero at extreme positions.
- Waves undergo reflections, refraction, interference, diffraction and polarization.

Point to ponder

The medium possesses both inertia and elasticity for propagation of waves.

Light is an electromagnetic wave. what is the medium for its transmission?

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